

AYODHYA

I arrived in Ayodhya after addressing my last public meeting in Lucknow on 5 December. It was around midnight. I spent the night at Janaki Mahal, where I normally stayed whenever I visited Ayodhya. The following morning, I was first taken to the place where the symbolic *kar seva* was intended to be performed with a fistful of sand from the banks of the Saryu river. From there, along with other leaders of the temple movement, I was taken to the dais, which had been put up on the terrace of the Ram Katha Kunj. Around 10 am, even before speeches by the leaders on the dais could start, someone came and told us that a small group of *kar sevaks* had mounted on one of the domes of the disputed structure. It was visible from the roof-top of the Ram Katha Kunj. I thus got visual confirmation of the message just received. The leaders on the dais immediately started pleading—through the public announcement system—the *kar sevaks* to come down. This was, however, to no avail. In fact, more and more people started climbing the dome.

Soon, I could see them carrying some implements and hammering away at the dome. I was upset, and so were other leaders on the dais. All the leaders made vehement appeals to the errant persons to immediately climb down and follow the discipline laid down by the organisers. I spoke with

great distress in my heart. Senior Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) leader H.V. Seshadri, who knew several languages, spoke in all of them since it was unclear who had broken the ranks and taken law into their own hands. Rajmata Scindia, a highly respected leader of the movement, made a passionate plea: "I am appealing to you as your mother not to do what you are doing." It was clear from all these appeals that what was happening on the dome was against the goals and principles of our movement.

All this, however, seemed to have no effect. I then asked Uma Bharati, who would be identifiable as a *sanyasin*, to go there and appeal to those who had mounted the dome to come down. She did go there and returned about forty-five minutes later to convey to me that some of the *kar sevaks* had heeded her advice, while many did not. I requested Pramod Mahajan, who had come with me from Lucknow, to go and stop what was happening. He went there and came back after sometime with a similar experience as that of Uma Bharati. Thereafter, I asked the lady police official, who was in charge of my security, to accompany me to the place of vandalism. Her reply surprised me. "Since I am in charge of your security, I will not agree to your going there," she said. Around this time, Ashok Singhal, president of the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP), tried to go to the spot to persuade these *kar sevaks* to desist from attacking the domes. I was told that

“ THE GENERAL MOOD OF THE POPULACE, INCLUDING employees and officials of the Uttar Pradesh government, after the tragic development in Ayodhya was that of jubilation. ”

